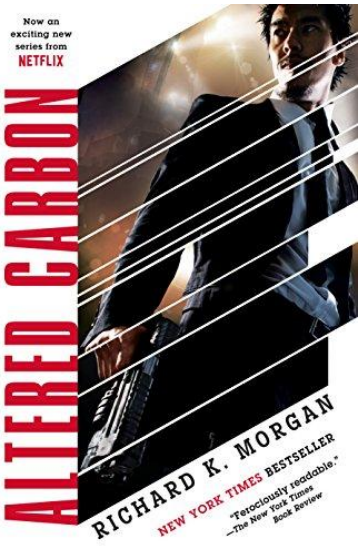




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Altered Carbon (Takeshi Kovacs Novels Book 1)

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112 Highlights | Yellow (112)

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The last thing she said to me when they walked her out of the cell was don't worry, kid, they'll store it.

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Don't worry, they'll store it. It was a superbly double-edged piece of street wisdom. Bleak faith in the efficiency of the penal system, and a clue to the elusive state of mind required to steer you past the rocks of psychosis. Whatever you feel, whatever you're thinking, whatever you are when they store you, that's what you'll be when you come out. With states of high anxiety, that can be a problem. So you let go. Stick it in neutral. Disengage and float. If you have time. I came thrashing up out of the tank, one hand plastered across my chest searching for the wounds, the other clutching at a nonexistent weapon. The weight hit me like a hammer, and I collapsed back into the flotation gel.

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I took a deep breath and went to face the mirror. This is always the toughest part. Nearly two decades I've been doing this, and it still jars me to look into the glass and see a total stranger staring back. It's like pulling an image out of the depths of an autostereogram. For the first couple of moments all you can see is someone else looking at you through a window frame. Then, like a shift in focus, you feel yourself float rapidly up behind the mask and adhere to its inside with a shock that's almost tactile. It's as if someone's cut an umbilical cord, only instead of separating the two of you, it's the otherness that has been severed and now you're just looking at your reflection in a mirror.

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“Takeshi Lev Kovacs,” he said, mispronouncing with the same skill as his minion in the tank room. “By the powers vested in me by the U.N. Justice Accord, I discharge you on lease to Laurens J. Bancroft, for a period not to exceed six weeks, at the end of which time your parole status will be reconsidered. Please sign here.” I took the pen and wrote my name in someone else’s handwriting next to the warden’s finger. Sullivan separated the top and bottom copies and handed me the pink one.

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You’re a lucky man, Kovacs. Sure. A hundred and eighty light-years from home, wearing another man’s body on a six-week rental agreement. Freight in to do a job that the local police wouldn’t touch with a riot prod. Fail and go back into storage. I felt so lucky I could have burst into song as I walked out the door.

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NO TO RESOLUTION 653!! ONLY GOD CAN RESURRECT!! D.H.F. = D.E.A.T.H. Cheers drowned out the speaker. “What’s this?” “Catholics,” Ortega said, lip curling. “Old-time religious sect.” “Yeah? Never heard of them.” “No. You wouldn’t have. They don’t believe you can digitize a human being without losing the soul.” “Not a widespread faith then.” “Just on Earth,” she said sourly. “I think the Vatican—that’s their central church—financed a couple of cryoships to Starfall and Latimer—” “I’ve been to Latimer. I never ran into anything like this.” “The ships only left at the turn of the century, Kovacs. They won’t get there for a couple more decades yet.”

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I stared at the leaflet in my hands. CAN A MACHINE SAVE YOUR SOUL? it demanded of me rhetorically. The word machine had been printed in script designed to resemble an archaic computer display. Soul was in flowing stereographic letters that danced all over the page. I turned over for the answer. NO!!!!

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“So cryogenic suspension is okay, but digitized human freight isn’t. Interesting.” I looked back at the glowing placards, musing. “What’s Resolution 653?” “It’s a test case going through the U.N. court,” Ortega said shortly. “Bay City public prosecutor’s office wants to subpoena a Catholic who’s in storage. Pivotal witness. The Vatican say she’s already dead and in the hands of God. They’re calling it blasphemy.”

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They've been grinding us down for the best part of two and a half thousand years. They've been responsible for more misery than any other organization in history. You know they won't even let their adherents practice birth control, for Christ's sake, and they've stood against every significant medical advance of the last five centuries.

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"Do you like it?" she asked. "Very much. This is from Mars, isn't it?" Her face underwent a change that I caught out of the corner of my eye. She was reassessing. I turned for a closer look at her face. "I'm impressed," she said. "People often are. Sometimes I do handsprings, too." She looked at me narrowly. "Do you really know what this is?" "Frankly, no. I used to be interested in structural art. I recognize the stone from pictures, but . . ." "It's a songspire." She reached past me and let her fingers trail down one of the upright branches. A faint sighing awoke from the thing and a perfume like cherries and mustard wafted into the air. "Is it alive?" "No one knows." There was a sudden enthusiasm in her tone that I liked her better for. "On Mars they grow to be a hundred meters tall, sometimes as wide as this house at the root. You can hear them singing for kilometers. The perfume carries, as well. From the erosion patterns, we think that most of them are at least ten thousand years old. This one might only have been around since the founding of the Roman Empire."

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"Maybe I could speak to you later," I amended. "Separately." "Yes, of course." Her eyes met mine, then danced aside.

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"Please don't think of me as a chauvinist, Mr. Kovacs. After nearly two hundred and fifty years of marriage, my relationship with Miriam is more politeness than anything. It really would be better if you spoke to her alone." "I understand." That was shaving the truth a bit, but it would do.

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"Envoy training was developed for the U.N. colonial commando units. That doesn't mean . . ." Doesn't mean every Envoy is a commando. No, not exactly, but then what is a soldier anyway? How much of special-forces training is engraved on the physical body and how much in the mind? And what happens when the two are separated?

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You can even decant your crack D.H.F. soldiers directly into sleeves with combat conditioning, jacked-up nervous systems, and steroid-built bodies. Then what do you do? They're in bodies they don't know, on a world they don't know, fighting for one bunch of total strangers against another bunch of total strangers over causes they've probably never even heard of and certainly don't understand. The climate is different, the language and culture are different, the wildlife and vegetation are different, the atmosphere is different, shit, even the gravity is different. They know nothing, and even if you download them with implanted local knowledge, it's a massive amount of information to assimilate at a time when they're likely to be fighting for their lives within hours of sleeving.

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the Envoy Corps. Neurachem conditioning, cyborg interfaces, augmentation—all this stuff is physical. Most of it doesn't even touch the pure mind, and it's the pure mind that gets freighted. That's where the corps started. They took psychospiritual techniques that Oriental cultures on Earth had known about for millennia and distilled them into a training system so complete that on most worlds graduates of it were instantly forbidden by law to hold any political or military office. Not soldiers, no. Not exactly. "I work by absorption," I finished. "Whatever I come into contact with, I soak up, and I use that to get by."

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"Do you have many children?" "Yes, I do. Very many." Bancroft smiled faintly. "When you have leisure and wealth, bringing children into the world is a pure joy. I have twenty-seven sons and thirty-four daughters."

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"Reasons the police chose to ignore." "Yes." I turned to face him. "All right. Let's hear it." "You're looking at it, Mr. Kovacs." He stood there in front of me. "I'm here. I'm back. You can't kill me just by wiping out my cortical stack." "You've got remote storage. Obviously, or you wouldn't be here. How regular is the update?" Bancroft smiled. "Every forty-eight hours." He tapped the back of his neck. "Direct needlecast from here into a shielded stack over at the PsyChaSec installation at Alcatraz. I don't even have to think about it." "And they keep your clones on ice there, as well." "Yes. Multiple units." Guaranteed immortality. I sat there thinking about that for a while, wondering how I'd like it. Wondering if I'd like it. "Must be expensive," I said at last. "Not really. I own PsyChaSec." "Oh."

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“What’s the last thing you remember?” “Tuesday, fourteenth August,” he said promptly. “Going to bed at about midnight.” “That was the last remote update.” “Yes, the needlecast would have gone through about four in the morning, but obviously I was asleep by then.” “So almost a full forty-eight hours before your death.” “I’m afraid so.” Optimally bad. In forty-eight hours, almost anything can happen. Bancroft could have been to the moon and back in that time.

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Will you require a weapon?” “Not at the moment, no.” One of Virginia Vidaura’s cardinal rules had always been find out the nature of your task before you choose your tools. That single sweep of charred stucco on Bancroft’s wall looked too elegant for this to be a shoot-’em-up carnival.

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He had been on the point of reaching into his shirt pocket, and now he completed the action awkwardly. He held out an inscribed card to me. “This is my gunmaker. I’ve told them to expect you.” I took the card and looked at it. The ornate script read LARKIN AND GREEN—ARMORERS SINCE 2203. Quaint. Below was a single string of numbers. I pocketed the card. “This might be useful later on,” I admitted

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“Curtis.” I glanced sideways at his impassive profile. “You want to cut the broadcast block for a minute?” He looked across at me with a slight curl of the lip. “Sure.” I settled back in the seat and fixed my eyes on the street again. “I’m not a tourist, Curtis. This is what I do for a living.” The street sellers’ catalogs came aboard like a swarm of delirium-induced hallucinations, slightly diffuse through lack of directed broadcast and blurring swiftly into each other as we glided along, but still an overload by any Harlanite standards.

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She glanced up and saw me watching her, nodded a brief acknowledgment, and put the serrated point of the blade in place. Then with a sharp blow to the haft of the knife, she chopped something loose. She looked up at the mohican with a grin. “Hear that?” She reached down into the gore and pulled out the stack between finger and thumb. It didn’t look like much, impact-resistant casing streaked with blood and barely the size of a cigarette butt, with the twisted filaments of the microjacks protruding stiffly from one end. I could see how the Catholics might not want to believe this was the receptacle of the human soul. “Gotcha, Dimi.” Ortega held up the stack to the light, then passed it and the knife to the mohican. She wiped her fingers on the corpse’s clothing. “Right, let’s get the other one out of the woman.”

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“So you know who this one is, as well?” She jerked around to look at me, whether out of surprise or dislike of my proximity I couldn’t be sure. “Yeah, this is Dimi the Twin, too. Ha, pun! The sleeve’s registered out of Ulan Bator, which for your information is the black-market downloading capital of Asia. See, Dimi’s not a very trusting soul. He likes to have people he can be sure of backing him up. And the circles Dimi mixes in, the only person you can really trust is you.” “Those sound like familiar circles. Is it easy to get yourself copied on Earth?” Ortega grimaced. “Getting easier all the time. Technology the way it is now, a state-of-the-art resleeving processor fits into a bathroom. Pretty soon it’s going to be an elevator. Then a suitcase.” She shrugged. “Price of progress.”

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“About the only way you can get it done on Harlan’s World is to file for a stellar-range ’cast, get an insurance copy held for the duration of the trip, and then cancel the transmission at the last minute. Fake a transit certificate, then claim a vital interest for a temporary download from the copy. This guy’s offworld and his business is crumbling, that kind of thing. Download once from the original at the transmission station, and again through the insurance company somewhere else. Copy One walks out of the station legally. He just changed his mind about going. Lots of people do. Copy Two never reports back to the insurance company for restorage. Costs a lot of money, though. You’ve got to bribe a lot of people, steal a lot of machine time to get away with it.”

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On Harlan's World, most people could afford to be resleeved at least once, but the point was that unless you were very rich, you had to live out your full span each time and old age, even with antisen treatment, was a wearying business. Second time around was worse because you knew what to expect. Not many had the stamina to do it more than twice. Most people went into voluntary storage after that, with occasional temporary resleevings for family matters, and of course, even those resleevings thinned out as time passed and new generations bustled in without the old ties. It took a certain kind of person to keep going, to want to keep going, life after life, sleeve after sleeve. You had to start out different, never mind what you might become as the centuries piled up.

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yawned like a snake trying to engorge an egg.

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I made a halfhearted attempt to masturbate, mind churning damply through images of Miriam Bancroft's voluptuous curves, but I kept seeing Sarah's pale body turned to wreckage by the Kalashnikov fire instead. And sleep dragged me under.

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"Welcome to Psychasec Alcatraz," a construct voice said briskly. "Please identify yourself within the fifteen-second security time limit." "Oumou Prescott and Takeshi Kovacs to see Director Nyman. We have an appointment." A thin green scanning laser flickered over us both from head to foot and then a section of the wall hinged smoothly back and down forming a passage inside.

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In the center was a circular desk where a receptionist sat behind a battery of secretarial equipment. No artificial constructs here, this was a real human being, a slim young man barely out of his teens who looked up with intelligent eyes as we approached. "You can go right through, Ms. Prescott. The director's office is up the stairs and third door on your right."

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We tramped through basement rooms cooled to the seven to eleven degrees Celsius recommended by the makers of altered carbon, peered at racks of the big thirty-centimeter expanded-format disks, and admired the retrieval robots that ran on wide-gauge rails along the storage walls.

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“It’s a duplex system,” Nyman said proudly. “Every client is stored on two separate disks in different parts of the building. Random code distribution, only the central processor can find them both, and there’s a lock on the system to prevent simultaneous access to both copies. To do any real damage, you’d have to break in and get past all the security systems twice.” I made polite noises.

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“Our satellite uplink operates through a network of no less than eighteen secure clearing orbital platforms, leased in random sequence.” Nyman was getting carried away with his own sales pitch. He seemed to have forgotten that neither Prescott nor myself were in the market for PsychasSec’s services. “No orbital is leased for more than twenty seconds at a time. Remote storage updates come in via needlecast, with no way to predict the transmission route.”

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The kind of enemies who used A.I.s to get at you didn’t need to finish you off with a particle blaster to the head. I was looking in the wrong place.

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The clones were vaguely discernible within, fetal bundles of arms and legs, but fully grown. Or at least, most were; toward the top of the dome I could see smaller sacs where new additions to the stock were being cultured. The sacs were organic, a toughened analog of womb lining, and they would grow with the fetus within to the meter and a half lozenges in the lower half of the vault. The whole crop hung there like an insane mobile, just waiting for some huge sickly breeze to stir it into motion. Nyman cleared his throat, and both Prescott and I shook off the paralyzed wonder that had gripped us on the threshold. “This may look haphazard,” he said, “but the spacing is computer generated.” “I know.” I nodded and went closer to one of the lower sacs. “It’s fractal derived, right?” “Ah, yes.” Nyman seemed almost to resent my knowledge.

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“Have you not been informed of her current condition?” “Yeah, she’s in psychosurgery,” I growled. “That doesn’t explain why there’s two of her here.” “Well.” Nyman darted a glance back at Prescott, as if to say that the divulging of further information involved some legal dimension. The lawyer cleared her throat. “PsychaSec has instructions from Mr. Bancroft to always hold a spare clone of himself and his immediate family ready for decanting. While Ms. Bancroft is committed to the Vancouver Psychiatric stack, both sleeves are stored here.”

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“Was there much activity the day Bancroft went to Osaka?” “No more than usual. Mr. Kovacs, the police have already been through these records. I really don’t see what value—” “Indulge me,” I suggested, not looking at him, and the Envoy cadences in my voice shut him down like a circuit breaker. Two hours later I was staring out of the window of another autocab as it kicked off from the Alcatraz landing quay and climbed over the Bay.

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“Up there, you got the comsats. Raining data. You can see it on some virtual maps; it looks like someone’s knitting the world a scarf.” He looked down at me again, eyes shiny. “Irene said that. Knitting the world a scarf. Some of that scarf is people. Digitized rich folks, on their way between bodies. Skeins of memory and feeling and thought, packaged up by numbers.” Now I thought I knew what was coming, but I kept quiet. “If you’re good, like she was, and you’ve got the equipment, you can sample those signals. They call them mindbites. Moments in the head of a fashion house princess, the ideas of a particle theorist, memories from a king’s childhood. There’s a market for this stuff.

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you can’t jump an Envoy—the conditioning won’t let it happen. I saw the attack coming almost before he knew he was going to do it himself, and I had the neurachem of my borrowed sleeve on-line fragments of a second later. He hit low, driving under the guard he thought I’d put up, looking for the body blows that would break up my ribs. The guard wasn’t there, and neither was I. Instead, I stepped inside the hooks of his punches, took him off balance with my weight, and tangled one leg amidst his. He stumbled back against the railing, and I drove a cruel elbow uppercut into his solar plexus. His face went gray with the shock. Leaning over, I pinned him to the rail and jammed the fork of my thumb and fingers into his throat. “That’s enough,” I snapped, a little unsteadily.

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“Lieutenant Takeshi Lev Kovacs,” the hotel said. “Also known as Mamba Lev, One Hand Rending, the Icepick; born Newpest, Harlan’s World, 35th May 187, colonial reckoning. Recruited to U.N. Protectorate Forces 11th September 204, selected for Envoy Corps enhancement 31st June 211 during routine screening—

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“Look,” she told me one day in a Millsport coffeehouse. “Shopping—actual, physical shopping—could have been phased out centuries ago if they’d wanted it that way.” “They who?” “People. Society.” She waved a hand impatiently. “Whoever. They had the capacity back then. Mail order, virtual supermarkets, automated debiting systems. It could have been done and it never happened. What does that tell you?” At twenty-two years old, a Marine Corps grunt via the street gangs of Newpest, it told me nothing. Carlyle took in my blank look and sighed. “It tells you that people like shopping. That it satisfies a basic, acquisitive need at a genetic level. Something we inherited from our hunter-gatherer ancestors. Oh, you’ve got automated convenience shopping for basic household items, mechanical food distribution systems for the marginalized poor. But you’ve also got a massive proliferation of commercial hives and speciality markets in food and crafts that people physically have to go to. Now why would they do that, if they didn’t enjoy it?” I probably shrugged, maintaining my youthful cool. “Shopping is physical interaction, exercise of decision-making capacity, sating of the desire to acquire, and an impulse to more acquisition, a scouting urge. It’s so basically fucking human when you think about it.

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“And what exactly is sir looking for in this sleeve?” I shrugged. “Something subtle. Something not. Projectile weapons. And a blade. The heavy one needs to be something like the Smith.” The mandroid became quite still. I could almost hear the whirring of data retrieval. I wondered briefly how a machine like this had come to wind up here. It had clearly not been designed for the job. On Harlan’s World, you don’t see many mandroids. They’re expensive to build, compared to a synthetic or even a clone, and most jobs that require a human form are better done by those organic alternatives. The truth is that a robot human is a pointless collision of two disparate functions: artificial intelligence, which really works better strung out on a mainframe, and hard-wearing, hazard-proof bodywork, which most cyberengineering firms designed to spec for the task at hand. The last robot I’d seen on the World was a gardening crab.

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It was the Envoy conditioning, stirring sluggishly to life in the wake of the Merge Nine, that told me. Enhanced proximity sense, the faintest shiver, and a figure in the corner of my eye once too often. This one was good. In a more crowded part of town I might have missed it, but here the pedestrians were too thin on the ground to provide much camouflage.

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Used in smaller doses, Reaper produced a depth of cool indifference to such things as pain, arousal, joy, and grief. All the detachment that men had pretended for centuries before the naked female form was there for the taking, in capsule. It was almost custom built for the male adolescent market. It was also an ideal military drug. Riding the Reaper, a Godwin's Dream renouncer monk could torch a village full of women and children and feel nothing but fascination for the way the flames melted flesh from bone.

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Drunk one night, Sarah had told me Women are the race, Tak. No two ways about it. Male is just a mutation with more muscle and half the nerves. Fighting, fucking machines. My own cross-sleeving had born that theory out. To be a woman was a sensory experience beyond the male. Touch and texture ran deeper, an interface with environment that male flesh seemed to seal out instinctively. To a man, skin was a barrier, a protection. To a woman, it was an organ of contact.

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Digital human storage hasn't made interrogation obsolescent, it's just brought back the basics. A digitized mind is only a snapshot. You don't capture individual thoughts any more than a satellite image captures an individual life. A psycho-surgeon can pick out major traumas on an Ellis model and make a few basic guesses about what needs to be done, but in the end she's still going to have to generate a virtual environment in which to counsel her patient, and go in there and do it. Interrogators, whose requirements are so much more specific, have an even worse time. What D.H.S. has done is make it possible to torture a human being to death, and then start again. With that option available, hypnotic and drug-based questioning went out the window long ago.

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His face looked back at me on the screen, pale. Scared, but not scared enough. Or maybe scared of someone else. Anyone who bar-codes their employees isn't likely to be the forgiving type, and the reflex of long-held obedience through hierarchy is usually enough to overcome fear of a combat death. That's how you fight wars, after all—with soldiers who are more afraid of stepping out of line than they are of dying on the battlefield.

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didn't take, or someone at OrgDam found

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but for all Miriam's diplomatic steerage, Nalan Ertekin did not seem unduly concerned to make her escape. I felt a momentary glimmer of admiration for her. Telling a U.N. executive—in effect, an officer of the Protectorate—that you're a Quellist is a bit like confessing to ritual slaughter at a vegetarian dinner; it's not really the done thing.

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Like Bancroft, MacIntyre had been a man of power, and like all men of power, when he talked of prices worth paying, you could be sure of one thing. Someone else was paying.

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Most virtual systems recreate you from self-images held in the memory, with a commonsense subroutine to prevent your delusions from impinging too much. I generally come out a little taller and thinner in the face than I usually am. In this case, the system seemed to have scrambled a myriad different perceptions from Kadmin's presumably long list of sleeves. I'd seen it done before, as a technique, but most of us grow rapidly attached to whatever sleeve we're living in, and that form blanks out previous incarnations. We are, after all, evolved to relate to the physical world. The man in front of me was different. His frame was that of a Caucasian Nordic, topping mine by nearly thirty centimeters, but the face was at odds. It began African, broad and deep ebony, but the color ended like a mask under the eyes, and the lower half was divided along the line of the nose, pale copper on the left, corpse white on the right. The nose was both fleshy and aquiline and mediated well between the top and bottom halves of the face, but the mouth was a mismatch of left and right sides that left the lips peculiarly twisted. Long straight black hair was combed manelike back from the forehead, shot through on one side with pure white. The hands, immobile on the metal table, were equipped with claws similar to the ones I'd seen on the giant Freak Fighter in Licktown, but the fingers were long and sensitive. He had breasts, impossibly full on a torso so overmuscled. The eyes, set in jet skin, were a startling pale green. Kadmin had freed himself from conventional perceptions of the physical. In an earlier age, he would have been a shaman; here, the centuries of technology had made him more. An electronic demon, a malignant spirit that dwelled in altered carbon and emerged only to possess flesh and wreak havoc. He would have made a fine Envoy.

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"Who sent you?" I asked him softly. "The Dog speaks! Is it a wolf I hear, Howling his lonely communion With the unpiloted stars, Or merely the self-importance and servitude In the bark of a dog? How many millennia did it take, Twisting and torturing The pride from the one To make a tool, The other?" I inhaled smoke and nodded. Like most Harlanites, I knew Quell's Poems and Other Prevarications more or less by heart. It was taught in schools in lieu of the later and weightier political works, most of which were still deemed too radical to be put in the hands of children. This wasn't a great translation, but it captured the essence. More impressive was the fact that anyone not actually from Harlan's World could quote such an obscure volume. I finished it for him. "And how do we measure the distance from spirit to spirit? And who do we find to blame?" "Have you come seeking blame, Mr. Kovacs?" "Among other things." "How disappointing." "You expected something else?" "No," Kadmin said with another smile. "Expectation is our first mistake. I meant, how disappointing for you." "Maybe."

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He shook his great piebald head. “Certainly. You will take no names from me. If you seek blame, I will have to bear it for you.” “That’s very generous, but you’ll remember what Quell said about lackeys.” “Kill them along the way, but count your bullets, for there are more worthy targets.” Kadmin chuckled deep inside himself. “Are you threatening me in monitored police storage?” “No. I’m just putting things into perspective.” I knocked ash off my cigarette and watched it sparkle out of existence before it reached the floor. “Someone’s pulling your strings; that’s who I’m going to wipe. You’re nothing. You I wouldn’t waste spit on.”

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Ortega’s lip curled. “Physical meetings are considered a touch of class these days. Only the cheap firms do business down the wires.”

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And anyway, how the fuck am I supposed to introduce you, Kovacs? ‘Hi, Keith, this is the ex-Envoy loose cannon your client tried to wipe on Sunday. He’d like to ask you a few questions.’ He’ll close up faster than an unpaid hooker’s hole.”

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I shrugged noncommittally. “Envoy techniques are largely reactive. I can’t react to something until it happens.” “I don’t want another bloodbath, Kovacs. It looks bad on the city stats.” “If there’s violence, it won’t be me that starts it.” “That’s not much of a guarantee. Haven’t you got any idea what you’re going to do?” “I’m going to talk.” “Just talk?” She looked at me disbelievingly. “That’s all?” I fitted my ill-fitting sunglasses back over my face. “Sometimes that’s all it takes,” I said.

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drawing the fine differences between war—mass murder of people wearing a uniform not your own; justifiable loss—mass murder of your own troops, but with substantial gains; and criminal negligence—mass murder of your own troops, without appreciable benefit. I sat in that courtroom for three weeks listening to them dress it like a variety of salads, and with every passing hour the distinctions, which at one point I’d been pretty clear on, grew increasingly vague. I suppose that proves how good they were.

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“So what the fuck is third-party retroassociative complicity?” “No idea. I made it up.” Her eyebrow went up. “No shit?” “Convinced you, huh? Know what, you could have given me a polygraph test while I was spinning it, and I would have convinced that, too. Basic Envoy tricks. Course, Rutherford will know that as soon as he looks it up, but it’s already served its purpose.” “Which is what?” “Provide the arena. Tell lies, you keep your opponent off balance. It’s like fighting on unfamiliar ground. Rutherford was rattled, but he smiled when I told him this stuff was why Kadmin was acting up.” I looked up through the windshield at the house above, formulating the scrapings of intuition into understanding. “He was fucking relieved when I said that. I don’t suppose normally he would have given that much away, but the bluff had him running scared, and him knowing better than me about something was that little ray of stability he needed. And that means he knows another reason why Kadmin changed behavior. He knows the real reason.” Ortega grunted approvingly. “Pretty good, Kovacs. You should have been a cop.

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The past is relevant only as data.

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“I was born on Understanding Day,” she added inconsequentially. “Really?” “Yep. January ninth. They named me Kristin after some whale scientist in Australia, worked on the original translation team.”

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“Bare-bones low-tech is all very well for the audience, but behind the scenes, well.” He gestured around at the gleaming facilities. “You can’t make an omelette without a little oil in the pan.”

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The storage tubes were racked on heavy chains like torpedoes on either side of us, jacked into a central monitor system at one end of the hold via thick black cables that twisted across the floor like pythons. The monitor unit itself squatted heavily ahead of us like an altar to some unpleasant spider god. We approached it on a metal jetty raised a quarter meter above the frozen writhings of the data cables. Behind it to left and right, set into the far wall, were the square glass sides of two spacious decanting tanks. The right-hand tank already held a sleeve, floating backlit and tethered cruciform by monitor lines.

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“Carnage was hiding something back there, right?” “From the amount he talked, I’d say yes.”

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However long she and Ryker had been together, the chemistry must have been devastating. I remembered reading somewhere how the initial pheromones of attraction between bodies appeared to undergo a form of encoding the longer said bodies were in proximity, binding them increasingly close. None of the biochemists interviewed appeared to really understand the process, but there had been some attempts to play with it in labs. Speeding up or interrupting had met with mixed results, one of which was empathin and its derivatives. Chemicals. I was still reeling from the cocktail of Miriam Bancroft, and I didn’t need this. I told myself, in no uncertain terms, I didn’t need this.

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The autocaster grumbled away down the street behind me, some of the more streetwise pedestrians skipping sharply sideways out of its ’cast radius.

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I put the chemicals back on the bar and regarded him gravely for a couple of seconds. “Then let me tell you something instead. When they make an Envoy, do you want to know what they do? They burn out every evolved violence limitation instinct in the human psyche. Submission signal recognition, pecking-order dynamics, pack loyalties. It all goes, tuned out a neuron at a time; and they replace it with a conscious will to harm.” He stared back at me in silence. “Do you understand me? It would have been easier to kill you just then. It would have been easier. I had to stop myself. That’s what an Envoy is, Curtis. A reassembled human. An artifice.”

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We settled at one of the clock-face tables, and Bautista fumbled in his pocket for cigarettes. I twitched, but when he offered me one I shook my head. Like Ortega, he looked surprised. “I quit.” “In that sleeve?” Bautista’s eyebrows lifted respectfully behind a veil of fragrant blue smoke. “Congratulations.”

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“Ryker.” The cop jetted smoke out of his nostrils and sat back. “Was working with the Sleeve Theft boys until a couple of years ago. They’re quite a sophisticated bunch compared to us. It ain’t so easy to steal a whole sleeve intact, and that breeds a smarter class of criminal. There’s some crossover of jurisdiction with Organic Damage, mostly when they start breaking down the bodies.

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Bautista drained what was left in his glass. “Old cop’s rule. Never drink alone.”

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“You telling me you can shut your feelings down just like that?” “You telling me you can’t?” she retorted. “All right, what did Laurens Bancroft want you to feel?” She stopped and faced me slowly. I felt uncomfortably as if I had just slapped her. Her face had gone masklike with remembrance. “Animal abandonment,” she said finally. “And then abject gratitude. And I stopped feeling them both as soon as he stopped paying me.” “And what do you feel now?” “Now?” Leila Begin looked out to sea, as if testing the temperature of the breeze against what was inside her. “Now I feel nothing, Mr. Kovacs.”

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Begin’s call had been routed through a Caribbean linkage broker, and the virtual time rented out of a Chinatown forum provider. Cheap, Ortega told me on the way in, and probably as secure as anywhere. Bancroft wants privacy, he spends half a million on discretion systems. Me, I just go talk where no one’s listening.

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Returning from the wide-open horizon of the beach virtuality was a shock. Opening my eyes on the banks of instrumentation just above my head, I suffered a momentary flashback to Harlan’s World. Thirteen years old and waking up in a virtual arcade after my first porn format. A low-ratio forum where two minutes of real time got me an experiential hour and a half in the company of two pneumatically breasted playmates whose bodies bore more resemblance to cartoons than real women. The scenario had been a candy-scented room of pink cushions and fake fur rugs with windows that gave poor resolution onto a nighttime cityscape. When I started running with the gangs and making more money, the ratio and resolution went up, and the scenarios got more imaginative, but the thing that never changed was the stale smell and the tackiness of the ’troles on your skin when you surfaced afterwards between the cramped walls of the coffin.

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more impressive by night. First of all, you've got the flashing lights casting dramatic color into everyone's faces, grim expressions steeped alternately in criminal red and smoky blue. Then there's the sound of the sirens on the night, like an elevator ratcheting down the levels of the city, the crackling voices of the comsets, somehow brisk and mysterious at the same time, the coming and going of dimly lit, bulky figures and snatches of cryptic conversation, the deployed technology of law enforcement for wakened bystanders to gape at, the lack of anything else going on to provide a vacuum backdrop. There can be absolutely nothing to see beyond this, and people will still watch for hours.

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"He knew me." I exhaled. "And he knew his Quellist history, too. That's fucking enough is what a Quellist guerrilla called Iffy Deme said when she died under interrogation during the Unsettlement on Harlan's World. She was wired with internal explosives, and she brought the house down. Sound familiar? Now who do we know who can swap Quell quotes like a Millsport native?" "He's in the fucking store, Kovacs. You can't get someone out of the store without—" "Without an A.I. With an A.I., you can do it. I've seen it done. Core command on Adoracion did it with our prisoners of war, like that." I snapped my fingers. "Like hooking elephant rays off a spawning reef." "As easy as that?" Ortega said ironically. I sucked down some more smoke and ignored her. "You remember when we were in virtual with Kadmin, we got that lightning effect across the sky?" "Didn't see it. No, wait, yeah. I thought it was a glitch." "It wasn't. It touched him. Reflected in the table. That's when he promised to kill me." I turned toward her and grinned queasily. The memory of Kadmin's virtual entity was clear and monstrous.

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Go primitive, Virginia Vidaura would have said. With an A.I. gunning for you, your only hope is to drop out of the electronic plane.

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A modern city—unbombed—is a logistical nightmare for this kind of evasion. Every building, every vehicle, every street is jacked into the web, and every transaction you make tags you for the data hounds.

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I'm stacked, backed up and I'm fifth dan And I'm not afraid of the Patchwork Man The small coin of urchin rhyme gleamed up at me from the silted bed of my childhood. But I was afraid.

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I couldn't really blame him for these potential betrayals, since I had no intention of turning up myself. Whatever he did was fine by me. In systems evasion, you must scramble the enemy's assumptions, Virginia said in my ear. Run as much interference as you can without breaking pace.

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"To actually remove the locator will require microsurgery similar to its placement. It can be done, but not without a full micro-op theater. Anything less, and you run the risk of damaging the neural interface, or even the spinal nerve canals." I shifted a little, uncomfortable at our proximity. "Yeah, I figured." "Well, then you've probably also figured," she said, burlesquing my accent, "that you can enter either a scrambling signal or a mirror code into the stack receiver to neutralize the broadcast signature." "If you've got the original signature." "If, as you say, you have the original signature." She reached into her pocket and produced a small, plastic-sheathed disk, weighed it in her palm for a moment, and then held it out to me. "Well, now you have." I took the disk and looked at it speculatively. "It's genuine. Any neuroelectrical clinic will confirm that for you. If you have doubts, I can recommend—" "Why are you doing this for me?" She met my eye, without flinching this time. "I'm not doing it for you, Mr. Kovacs. I am doing this for myself."

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"I am not a stranger to corruption, Mr. Kovacs. No one can work for long in a justice facility and fail to recognize a gangster. The synthetic was one of a type. Warden Sullivan has had dealings with these people as long as I have had tenure at Bay City. Police jurisdiction ends outside our doors, and administration salaries are not high." She looked back at me. "I have never taken payment from these people, nor, until now, had I acted on their behalf. But equally, I have never stood against them. It has been very easy to bury myself in my work and pretend not to see what goes on." "The human eye is a wonderful device," I quoted from *Poems and Other Prevarications* absently. "With a little effort, it can fail to see even the most glaring injustice." "Very aptly put." "It's not mine."

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high on the bench's backrest and chiseled upside down, like a tiny pool of inverted calm in all the rage and desperate pride, I found a curious haiku in kanji: Pull on the new flesh like borrowed gloves And burn your fingers once again. The author must have been hanging over the back of the bench when he cut it into the wood, but still each character was executed with elegant care.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 213

A sudden burst of crying over to my right jolted me out of the reverie. A young black woman and her two children, also black, were staring at the stooped, middle-aged white man standing before them in tattered U.N. surplus fatigues. Family reunion. The young woman's face was a mask of shock—it hadn't hit her properly yet—and the smaller child, probably no more than four, just didn't get it at all. She was looking right through the white man, mouth forming the repeated question where's daddy, where's daddy? The man's features were glistening in the rainy light from the roof; he looked like he'd been crying since they dragged him out of the tank. I rolled my head to an empty quadrant of the hall. My own father had walked right past his waiting family and out of our lives when he was resleeved. We never even knew which one he was, although I sometimes wonder if my mother didn't catch some splinter of recognition in an averted gaze, some echo of stance or gait as he passed. I don't know if he was too ashamed to confront us, or more likely too set up with the luck of drawing a sleeve sounder than his own alcohol-wrecked body had been, and already plotting a new course for other cities and younger women. I was ten at the time. The first I knew about it was when the attendants ushered us out of the facility just short of locking up for the night. We'd been there since noon.

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"You know who that place belongs to?" "I guessed." She shook her head. "Triad noodlehouse. Hell of a place for an interrogation. Or do you just like living dangerously?" I shrugged. "Where I come from, criminals stay out of other people's fights. They're a gutless lot, generally. Much more likely to get interference from a solid citizen."

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As we started to descend, Trepp unjacked herself with a flutter of eyelids that meant she hadn't bothered to disconnect the chip synapses first—strictly advised against by most manufacturers, but maybe she was showing off.

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“Ray,” I said, in Amanglic. “I should have fucking seen this one on the launch pad.” Reileen Kawahara stepped from a doorway to one side of the circular chamber where the basilica ended, and made an ironic bow.

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“Power is habitually buried,” she said. “Think of the Protectorate bunkers on Harlan’s World. Or the caverns the Envoy Corps hid you in while you were made over in their image. The essence of control is to remain hidden from view, is it not?”

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I looked down at the lettering beneath my feet and thought it through, link by link. “Francisco Franco,” Kawahara said, mistaking the direction of my gaze for focused interest. “Petty tyrant a long time back. He built this place.” “Trepp said it belonged to the Catholics.” Kawahara shrugged. “Petty tyrant with delusions of religion. Catholics get on well with tyranny. It’s in the culture.”

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Kawahara shook her head regretfully. She was smiling. “Always the same, Kovacs. Full of sound and fury, signifying nothing. Romantic nihilism. Haven’t you learned anything since New Beijing?” “There are some arenas so corrupt that the only clean acts possible are nihilistic.” “Oh, that’s Quell, isn’t it? Mine was Shakespeare, but then I don’t expect colonial culture goes back that far, does it?”

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The human race has dreamed of heaven and hell for millennia. Pleasure or pain unending, undiminished, and uncurtailed by the strictures of life or death. Thanks to virtual formatting, these fantasies can now exist. All that is needed is an industrial-capacity power generator. We have indeed made hell—and heaven—on earth.

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Suppose you know someone, a long time ago. You share things, drink deeply of each other. Then you drift apart; life takes you in different directions; the bonds are not strong enough. Or maybe you get torn apart by external circumstance. Years later, you meet that person again, in the same sleeve, and you go through it all over again. What's the attraction? Is this the same person? They probably have the same name, the same approximate physical appearance, but does that make them the same? And if not, does that make the things that have changed unimportant or peripheral? People change, but how much? As a child I'd believed there was an essential person, a sort of core personality around which the surface factors could evolve and change without damaging the integrity of who you were. Later, I started to see that this was an error of perception caused by the metaphors we were used to framing ourselves in. What we thought of as personality was no more than the passing shape of one of the waves in front of me. Or, slowing it down to more human speed, the shape of a sand dune. Form in response to stimulus. Wind, gravity, upbringing. Gene blueprinting. All subject to erosion and change. The only way to beat that was to go on stack forever.

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a primitive sextant functions on the illusion that the sun and stars rotate around the planet we are standing on, our senses give us the illusion of stability in the universe, and we accept it, because without that acceptance, nothing can be done.

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the fact that a sextant will let you navigate accurately across an ocean does not mean that the sun and stars do rotate around us.

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there is nothing but flux. Anything you wish to even perceive as an Envoy, let alone create or achieve, must be carved out of that flux.

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Most of the police work gets picked up by private contractors. The local government handles it by tying payment to the assets of the criminals you bring down." "Interesting incentive," I said reflectively. "Ought to make for a lot of rich people getting busted." "Yeah, they say it works that way. The yacht was Ryker's piece. He did a lot of the groundwork on the case, and he was wounded in the firefight."

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good lie should shadow the truth closely enough to draw substance from it, but this was something else, something altogether more unnerving. I felt like a hunter who has tracked a swamp panther a little too close for comfort, and expects at any moment to see it rear up out of the swamp in all its fanged and tendril-maned horror. The truth was here, somewhere.

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Envoy intuition was a form of subliminal recognition, an enhanced awareness of pattern that the real world too often abraded with its demand for detailed focus. Given enough traces of continuity, you could make a leap that enabled you to see the whole as a kind of premonition of real knowledge. Working from that model, you could fill in the bits later. But there was a certain minimum you needed to get airborne. Like old-style linear prop aircraft, you needed a run up, and I didn't have it. I

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Do you know what a water carrier is?" She shook her head. "In Fission City it's what they used to call the gang enforcers. See, if someone refused to pay protection, or informed to the police, or just didn't jump fast enough when the local yakuza boss said frog, the standard punishment was to drink contaminated water. The enforcers used to carry it around in shielded flasks, siphoned off low-grade reactor cooling systems. They'd turn up at the offender's house one night and tell him how much he had to drink. His family would be made to watch. If he didn't drink, they'd start cutting his family one by one until he did. You want to know how I know that delightful piece of Earth history trivia?" Ortega said nothing, but her mouth was tight with disgust. "I know because Kawahara told me. That's what she used to do when she was a kid. She was a water carrier. And she's proud of it."

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“I have what you want,” she said offhandedly. “A dormant version of the Rawling virus will be delivered to Silset Holdings tomorrow morning after eight o’clock. Address 1187 Sacramento. They’ll know you’re coming.” “And the activator codes?” “Delivery under separate cover. Trepp will contact you.” I nodded. U.N. law governing transfer and ownership of war viruses was clear to the point of bluntness. Inert viral forms could be owned as subjects for study, or even, as one bizarre test case had proved, private trophies. Ownership or sale of an active military virus, or the codes whereby a dormant virus could be activated, was a U.N. indictable offense, punishable with anything between a hundred and two hundred years storage. In the event of the virus actually being deployed, the sentence could be upped to erasure. Naturally these penalties were applicable only to private citizens, not military commanders or government executives. The powerful are jealous of their toys.

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Any reason why I couldn’t have my own body back? I’ll be a lot faster in my own—” “I know. Unfortunately it’s out of my hands. Did they tell you how long you’ve been in the store?” “Four years, someone said.” “Four and a half,” I said, glancing at the release forms I’d signed. “I’m afraid in the meantime, someone took a shine to your sleeve and bought it.” “Oh.” She was silent then. The shock of waking up inside someone else’s body for the first time is nothing compared to the sense of rage and betrayal you feel knowing that someone somewhere is walking around inside you. It’s like the discovery of infidelity, but at the intimacy range of rape. And like both those violations, there’s nothing you can do about it. You just get used to it.

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Take what is offered, and that must sometimes be enough.

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I saw Bancroft’s antique telescope, trained on the heavens and the tiny motes of light that were Earth’s first hesitant steps beyond the limits of the solar system. Fragile arks carrying the recorded selves of a million pioneers and the deep-frozen embryo banks that might someday resleeve them on distant worlds, if the promise of the vaguely understood Martian astrogation charts bore fruit.

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they're looking for borderline psychopathic tendencies. That's why they do most of their recruiting from the military in the first place." Trepp looked put out. "I've got borderline psychopathic tendencies." "Yeah, I don't doubt it, but the point is, the number of civilians with those tendencies and a sense of team spirit is pretty limited. They're opposing values. The chances of them both arising naturally in the same person are almost nil. Military training takes the natural order and fucks with it. It breaks down any resistance to psychopathic behavior at the same time as it builds fanatical loyalties to the group. Package deal. Soldiers are perfect Envoy material."

Page 275

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"I slept with my husband, and I feel like he's been unfaithful to me." A choked laugh. She smeared angrily at her eyes. "I feel like I've been unfaithful. To something. You know, when they put me away I left a body and a family behind. Now I don't have either." She looked down at herself again. She lifted her hands and turned them, fingers spread. "I don't know what I feel," she said. "I don't know what to feel." There was a lot I could have said. A lot that has been said, written, researched, and disputed on the subject. Trite little magazine-length summings-up of the problems inherent in resleeving—how to make your partner love you again, in any body; trite, interminable psychological tracts—some observations of secondary trauma in civil resleeving; even the sanctified manuals of the fucking Envoy Corps itself had something trite to say on the matter. Quotes, informed opinion, the ravings of the religious and the lunatic fringe. I could have thrown it all at her. I could have told her that what she was going through was quite normal for an unconditioned human. I could have told her that it would pass with time. That there were psychodynamic disciplines for dealing with it. That millions of other people survived it. I could even have told her that whichever God she owed nominal allegiance to was watching over her. I could have lied, I could have reasoned. It all would have meant about the same, because the reality was pain, and right now there was nothing anyone could do to take it away. I said nothing.

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You know what the risks are? You know what you're asking me to do?" I turned to look her in the eye. "Yes. I know." Her mouth clamped down on a tremor. "Good. Then let's do it." The run took less than three days to set up. Irene Elliott turned stone-cold pro and made it happen that way.

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Bancroft shifted uncomfortably at the word, and I felt a stab of elation run through me. Virus! Even Meths were afraid of the invisible corroder, because even they, with their remote storage and their clones on ice, were not immune. Viral strike! Stack down! Bancroft was off balance.

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“Whatever. If Carnage wakes up not knowing, he might make some private inquiries, but he ain’t going to be in too much of a hurry to let the police department in on it. And if he wakes up knowing—” He spread his hands. “—he’ll make less noise than a Catholic orgasm. I think we’re in the clear here.”

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“Look,” the Ryker copy said, “I’m you. I know everything you know. What’s the harm in talking about this stuff?” “If you know everything I know, what’s the point of talking about it?” “Sometimes, it helps to externalize things. Even if you talk to someone else about it, you’re usually talking to yourself. The other guy’s just providing a sounding board. You talk it out.” I sighed. “I don’t know. I buried all that shit about Dad a long time ago; it’s a long time dead.” “Yeah, right.” “I’m serious.” “No.” He flicked a finger at me the way I had pointed at Bancroft when he didn’t want to face my facts on the balcony of Suntouch House. “You’re lying to yourself. Remember that pimp we met in Lazlo’s pipehouse the year we joined Shonagon’s Eleven? The one we nearly killed before they pulled us off him?” “That was just chemicals. We were off our head on tetrameth, showing off because of the Eleven stuff. Fuck, we were only sixteen.” “Bullshit. We did it because he looked like Dad.” “Maybe.” “Fact. And we spent the next decade and a half killing authority figures for the same reason.” “Oh, give me a fucking break! We spent that decade and a half killing anyone who got in the way. It was the military; that’s what we did for a living. And anyway, since when is a pimp an authority figure?” “Okay, maybe it was pimps we spent fifteen years killing. Users. Maybe that’s what we were paying back.” “He never pimped Mom out.” “Are you sure? Why were we so hot to hit the Elizabeth Elliott angle like a fucking tactical nuke? Why the accent on whorehouses in this investigation?” “Because,” I said, sinking a finger of whiskey, “that is what this investigation has been about from the beginning. We went after the Elliott angle because it felt right. Envoy intuition. The way Bancroft treated his wife—” “Oh, Miriam Bancroft. Now there’s another whole disk we could spin.” “Shut up. Elliott was a pretty fucking good sounding shot. We wouldn’t have got to Head in the Clouds without that trip to Jerry’s Biocabins.”

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Jimmy de Soto had always said it was sacrilege to sink more than five fingers of single malt on any one occasion. After that, he maintained, you might as well be drinking blended.

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It took about half an hour to lay it out, while Ortega stood about or paced restlessly in and out of the bubblefab. I couldn't blame her. Over the past ten days she'd had to face the breakdown of practically every professional tenet she owned, and she was now committed to a project that, if it went wrong, offered a bristling array of hundred-year or better storage offenses for all concerned. I think, without Bautista and the others behind her, she might not have risked it, even with her cordial hatred of the Meths, even for Ryker.

Page 326

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This makes what we did to the A.I. look like a systems check. To do this, to even attempt this, I've got to have a virtual forum." "That's not a problem. Anything else?" "That depends on what counterintrusion systems Head in the Clouds is running."

Page 371

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You take what is offered, Virginia Vidaura said somewhere. And that must sometimes be enough.

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"Go on thinking like that, nothing'll ever change for you." "Kristin, nothing ever does change." I jerked a thumb back at the crowd outside. "You'll always have morons like that, swallowing belief patterns whole so they don't have to think for themselves. You'll always have people like Kawahara and the Bancrofts to push their buttons and cash in on the program. People like you to make sure the game runs smoothly and the rules don't get broken too often. And when the Meths want to break the rules themselves, they'll send people like Trepp and me to do it. That's the truth, Kristin. It's been the truth since I was born a hundred and fifty years ago, and from what I read in the history books, it's never been any different. Better get used to it."

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Then I had it locked down. I turned back to the next step, found a chuckle somewhere in my chest, and coughed it out. The chuckle fired up and became a laugh of sorts. Get to the next screen.